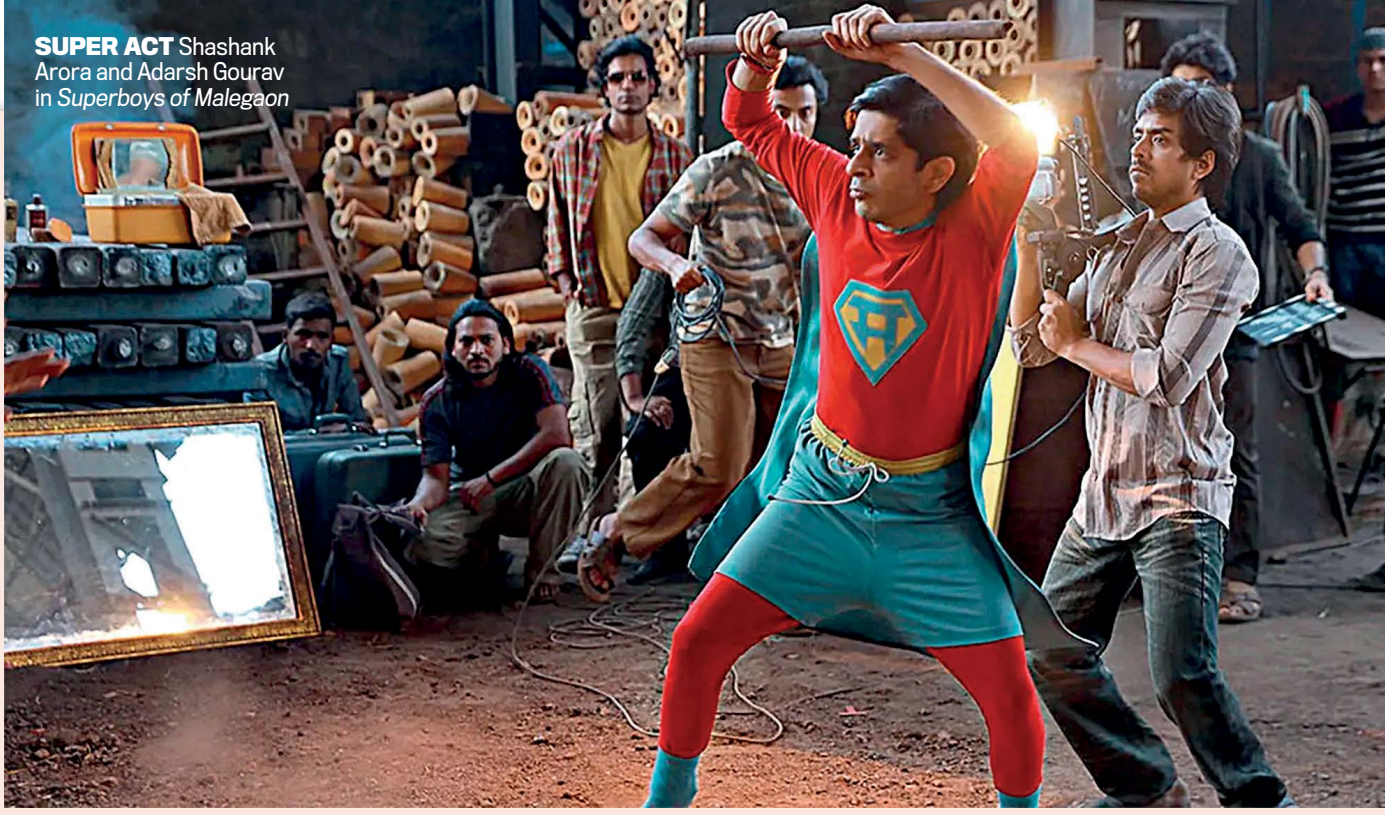


SUPER ACT Shashank Arora and Adarsh Gourav in *Superboys of Malegaon*

At

the Osian Film Festival in New Delhi in 2010, Zoya Akhtar had a fan moment of her own as she approached Shaikh Nasir, the Malegaon-based director of wacky spoof films like *Malegaon ke Sholay*, *Malegaon ka James Bond*, *Malegaon ke Shaan* and *Malegaon ka Superman*. It's the making of the latter which would be immortalised in Faiza Ahmed Khan's beloved documentary *Supermen of Malegaon*, which both Akhtar and Reema Kagti watched and loved. "When he met Zoya he was like 'I am a big fan of your father [screenwriter Javed Akhtar] and I have copied all his work'," recalls Kagti with a smile. "As we started getting to know more about his family and friends, we realised there's a feature film in here." The result is *Superboys of Malegaon* featuring Adarsh Gourav as Nasir with Vineet Kumar Singh as the writer-friend Farogh Jafri and Shashank Arora as the actor-friend Shafique.

Kagti knew she wanted to be the one to direct it for she saw many parallels between her and Nasir. In her formative years spent in the small town of Digboi, Assam, Kagti too would frequent small cinemas "to have a larger-than-life vicarious experience" and watched pirated VHS and VCDs to get access to a magical world. Her cinematic influences—Bruce Lee, Amitabh Bachchan, Charlie Chaplin—were the same as Nasir's. "I realised for a director, regardless of wherever you are functioning, there's always the hustle, the *jugaad*, the need to inspire and not order people around to rise to the occasion, and be a bit of a manipulator." What makes Shaikh's story incredible for Kagti is the purity of his pursuit and his decision to stay put in Malegaon which resulted in a parallel filmmaking industry blossoming. Or as Nasir proclaims in the film: "*Bambai ko idhar laana padega* [We will bring Mumbai here]."

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Within Zoya-Reema's oeuvre which has resulted in features like *Zindagi Na Milegi Dobara* and *Dil Dhadakne Do*, *Superboys of Malegaon* stands closest to *Gully Boy* as it zooms in on a minority community on the fringes and one man's devotion to his craft against all odds. There's also some likeness to *Luck By Chance* as here too there's a homage to cinema by shining a light on those who find ingenuity amidst adversities. More than anything though, the film is about how it takes a village to make a film—in Nasir's case most of the cast and crew are friends from diverse professions—a loom worker, a dry-fruits seller, a tea-stall owner and a photo-studio owner. Central to *Superboys...* are his late friends, Farokh and Shafique, also his biggest cheerleaders.

With *Superboys...*, Reema-Zoya's production banner, Tiger Baby, continues on its quest to broaden their worldview by roping in new writers. In this case, they both settled on stand-up comic-author-lyricist-screenwriter Varun Grover. "We were lucky he was free to do it," adds Kagti. Grover travelled to Malegaon to research the film and spent time talking to those involved in its industry. He also found a treasure trove of information courtesy Nasir himself, who has meticulously assembled an archive documenting his own life. "He has maintained two to three sets of newspaper clippings. If there was a picnic